

missile. But while the Russian space programme was centralised and unified, the American one was fragmented, with several groups competing amongst themselves to achieve significant advances. Of course, this also meant that scientists got ample room to play around with the gadgetry. For example, while the V-2 rocket was already able to reach space, the Douglas Aircraft Company and the Guggenheim Aeronautical Laboratory got together to build and send the WAC Corporal into space – the first American rocket meant for scientific purpose. It also used a different mixture of liquid elements as its fuel (aniline and furfuryl alcohol) and nitric acid as the oxidizer. While successful, the WAC Corporal was nothing more than an experiment.

The most significant non-military achievement of this era, though, was in 1946 when a team of researchers strapped a camera onto a V-2 rocket and managed to take the first photo of Earth from Space.

Launched from the White Sands Missile Range in New Mexico, the V-2 rocket was equipped with a standard 35-millimetre video camera that would snap a picture at an interval of 1.5 seconds. Since the rocket would come back down and crash, the film of the camera was encased in a protective reinforced steel box. The rocket climbed above the 100-kilometre line and fell back down as expected. The film was intact and provided the first view of the Earth from space.

The First Living Organism In Space

With the focus of the space programmes slowly turning to the ability to send humans into space and find out more about ‘the great beyond’, it became extremely important to find out the effect that radiation and spaceflight would have on living organisms.

In 1947, the Americans sent the first living organisms into space aboard a V-2 rocket. A few fruit flies were packed into a container with cotton and rye seeds, and were successfully recovered alive after the rocket reached space and returned.

With monkeys being the closest relatives of humans in the animal world, it was only a matter of time before scientists began experimenting with sending them into space. Albert I was the first monkey sent aboard a V2 rocket in 1948, but he suffocated and died during the flight – and the rocket never reached space either.

Albert II became the first monkey to reach space aboard a V-2 rocket in 1949, and he did not suffocate either. But due to a parachute failure, Albert II died on impact. Albert III and IV followed – with both not surviving